



CGIAR Quick Style Guide

Guidelines management

Accountable	Managing Director of Communications and Outreach
Responsible	Senior Director, Communications and Outreach
Consulted	C&O Transition Task Team, C&O Team members
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CGIAR reserves the right to revise the conditions of these Guidelines at any time.

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General objective

This style guide is intended to ensure consistency across CGIAR written products by providing guidance on spelling, punctuation, formatting, and other matters of style. The style preferences presented here are based on a review of CGIAR Center policies and bring together the most common style preferences. We welcome feedback and aim to incorporate contributions from all our staff, writers, and editors on an ongoing basis.

Primary references

The primary references for CGIAR style are The Chicago Manual of Style (CMS) and Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary. For style questions that are not addressed in this quick guide, please refer to CMS or, for science publications, the Council of Science Editors' Scientific Style and Format guide. For citation and figure styles, The World Bank Style Guide can also be useful.

American spelling and punctuation (e.g. commas and fullstops/periods inside quotation marks) is preferred; exceptions can be made for publications intended largely for countries and regions where British English is more common or when preferred by donors. For British spelling, the Concise Oxford Dictionary can be used.

General notes

Acronyms and other abbreviations

Spell out acronyms and other abbreviations on first use and use only the acronym thereafter, when they are used frequently in a publication. (In an edited volume, spell out when the name first appears in each chapter.)

Some organization names are never spelled out, including CGIAR. For short publications, it is not necessary to spell out very common abbreviations, notably GDP, IT, M&E, NGO, R&D, and UN.

When spelling out abbreviations that do not stand for proper names, the spelled-out version should not be capitalized (for example, gross domestic product [GDP]; randomized controlled trial [RCT]; nitrogen [N]).

Units of measure should be abbreviated when following a number (3 ha, 45 km) but not otherwise (many kilometers, fewer hectares). Commonly used units do not need to be spelled out on first use. Abbreviate metric tons as “t,” not “mt” or “MT.”

Capitalization

Proper nouns, including names of places, institutions, and brands should be written in title case.

Program and project names should be written in title case; they should not be italicized or put in quotation marks, even when in another language.

People's titles should only be capitalized when they precede the person's name.

Names of institutions and government bodies, such as ministries, should only be capitalized when referring to particular entities.

Titles

In titles, headlines and subtitles sentence case should be used.

Prefer	Avoid
President Mary Smith	Mary Smith, the President
The president arrived.	The President arrived.
The Ministry of Agriculture signed the accord.	The Ministry signed the accord.
The ministries that manage fisheries	The Ministries that manage fisheries

Punctuation

Use a serial (Oxford) comma (preceding the word “and” or “or”) in a series of three or more words or phrases (apples, oranges, and lemons). Use semicolons in lists that include internal punctuation (apples, which are red; lemons, which are sour; and oranges, which are sweet).

Punctuation for lists

For bulleted lists, always use a colon between the introductory clause or sentence and the list that follows. An exception to this case is following a title or header. Capitalize each item and use a period with complete sentences. Avoid the use of semicolons in a bulleted list. Ensure consistent application of these rules throughout your document.

Five steps for a pleasant day at the beach:	OR	You will need these items at the beach:
• Apply sunscreen. • Bring a good paperback. • Have an ice cream cone.		• Strong sunscreen • Large sun umbrella • Lounge chair • Money for snacks

Word treatment and usage

Writing about CGIAR

CGIAR is never spelled out and does not take “the” when it stands alone.

Centers that are part of the One CGIAR transition are referred to as “CGIAR Research Centers.” Centers that are not part of the transition should be referred to by their current names.

The CGIAR Research Initiative names use title case and are not italicized in long or short forms (except for acronyms, which are all caps). CGIAR Research Initiatives should be used in the first instance, thereafter Initiative can be used.

Always capitalize System Board, System Council, Executive Management Team and Senior Leadership Team.

Correct	Incorrect
CGIAR will hold a conference.	The Consultative Group on International Agricultural Research will hold a conference.
The CGIAR Research Initiatives are underway.	CGIAR research initiatives are underway.
The National Policies and Strategies Initiative (NPS) works in several countries.	The <i>National policies and strategies</i> initiative works in several countries.

Compound words

In general, compound adjectives should be hyphenated, especially if there is a risk of misinterpretation (long-term plan; solar-power equipment; small-scale farmers). Do not hyphenate directional words except in a proper name (southwest, northeast).

Compounds formed with prefixes and suffixes are normally closed (no hyphen). A hyphen should be used (1) before a capitalized word or a numeral (non-English or post-1984); (2) before a compound term (non-self-sustaining); and (3) to separate two vowels or other combinations of letters or syllables that might cause misreading, such as anti-intellectual, extra-alkaline, co-opt, co-sponsor. An en dash should be used before an open compound (pre–Viet Nam War).

agri/agro	agribusiness, agrifood, agritech, agroecology, agroforestry <i>but</i> agro-industry, agro-processing
multi	multicountry, multidisciplinary, multisectoral, multiyear
post	postdoctoral, postharvest, postfarm, postwar <i>but</i> post-farmgate, post-COVID, post–World War I
pre	

pro	preindustrial, premodern, preregistration, prewar, <i>but</i> pre-Columbian, pre-harvest season
wide	proindustrial, promarket, <i>but</i> pro-Canadian, pro-poor, pro-trade
	economywide, regionwide, <i>but</i> Africa-wide

Non-English words

Do not italicize non-English words, abbreviations, or foreign phrases commonly used in English, such as *a priori*, *coup*, *e.g.*, *et al.*, *etc.*, *ex post*, *ex ante*, *i.e.*, *in situ*, or *de facto*.

Do not italicize or capitalize the names of currencies (yen, birr, dollars).

Use italics for non-English words or phrases not commonly used in English (*maquila*, for example). Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary is the preferred guide; if a non-English word or phrase is included in the main part of the dictionary, there is no need to italicize it.

If a non-English word does require italics, it generally should be italicized throughout the publication. However, if it is used quite frequently in the publication, italicize it only on its first use.

Exception: Do not italicize the names of specific institutions, places, or programs, regardless of which language they are in.

Avoiding discriminatory language

Language choices should avoid sexist, racist, homophobic, disablist, or other biases and stereotypes.

Do not refer to the racial or cultural background or the gender of a person or group unless there is a strong reason for doing so.

Avoid judgmental terms, such as "First World" or "Third World." Use "developed and developing countries" or "high-, low-, and middle-income countries."

Select nondiscriminatory terms: chairperson not chairman; fisher not fisherman; work hours not man hours; disability not handicap; people with disabilities not the disabled; etc.

Avoid patronizing language, such as "lifting people out of poverty." People empower themselves, raise themselves out of poverty, and so on (for example, "increasing women's access to land can help them control planting decisions").

Where possible, use "they" and "their" when referring to more than one person. Use "he" and "him" only when referring to men, and "she" and "her" only when referring to women. Avoid the use of "he or she" (and never use "s/he" or "she/he") when referring to a person or people whose gender is unspecified (unless the intention is to emphasize the inclusion of men and women). Where practical, avoid use of "they" or "their" as singular.

Prefer	Avoid
African farmers on average produce only enough food to feed their families.	An African farmer on average produces only enough food to feed his family.
An African farmer on average produces only enough food to feed his or her family.	An African farmer on average produces only enough food to feed their family.

Gender terminology

Below are terms that are often confused in writing about gender-related issues.

Gender

- Means socially constructed relationships/differences between men and women.
- Includes the roles, responsibilities, and opportunities associated with being male or female in a given culture — characteristics that vary among cultures and change over time.

Gender ≠ Sex

- Gender = social relations/differences between women and men.
- Sex = biological differences between males and females (animals and homo sapiens).

Gender ≠ Women

- Men are also included in the concept of gender.
- “Gender empowerment” is incorrect terminology. Refer to “women’s empowerment” or “gender equality/equity.”

“Male” and “Female”

- These are adjectives that are used to describe something. For example, a female cat, a male turkey.

“Men” and “Women”

- These are nouns that are used to refer to adult people.
- “Women” and “men” should also be used as adjectives denoting gender (women farmers and men farmers not female farmers and male farmers).

“Gender analysis”

- A set of tools for uncovering gender differences between men and women in order to ensure that our research produces policy recommendations that are appropriate to the needs of both men and women.

Country names

CGIAR follows United Nations guidance on country names. A full list of UN Member states' accepted names and their country codes is available at: <https://unstats.un.org/unsd/methodology/m49/>.

In formal mentions, use the country name as listed. Within text, the common names of countries (for example, "Tanzania" not "United Republic of Tanzania") are generally preferred.

Take note of: Côte d'Ivoire (not Ivory Coast); Gambia (not The Gambia); Türkiye (not Turkey); and Viet Nam (not Vietnam).

Scientific names

Genus and species should always be italic, with the genus capitalized and the species lowercase (unless derived from a proper noun). Genus is always before the epithet (*Solanum tuberosum*). Modifiers to species names are not italic (e.g., cv., var., ssp.)

Higher taxa — phylum, class, order, and family — are capitalized but not italicized.

The genus name should be spelled out on first occurrence and subsequently may be abbreviated to the first letter (*S. tuberosum*). If there is more than one genus starting with the same letter, use distinguishing abbreviations (for example, *Sitotroga cerealella* and *Stenocarpella macrospora* could become *Sit. cerealella* and *Sten. macrospora*) or spell out in full.

CMS provides additional information.

Specific word and word treatment preferences

For the sake of consistency across CGIAR publications, some specific word preferences are provided here.

Prefer

afterward, toward

agrifood

amid

among

because (preferred for causal relationships)

compared with (when noting differences)

in contrast

data are (always plural)

different from

internet

more than, less than (preferred for quantities)

per year

Avoid

afterwards, towards

agri-food

amidst

amongst

as, since, while

compared to (best used for noting similarities)

by contrast

data is

different than

Internet

over, under

per annum

to	in order to
use	utilize
while	whilst
global South	Global South

Numbers, dates, measurements, and currencies

Arabic Numbers

General

Spell out whole numbers from zero to nine and use numerals for 10 and up. When numbers of less than 10 are used in a sentence with numbers greater than 10, numerals can be used for all. Treat numbers of the same category alike throughout a paragraph. Numbers in the millions and above can be written as 10 million, 45 billion, etc. (not 5 thousand).

Numbers greater than 999 should contain commas to indicate thousands, except for page numbers in citations and references.

Correct	Incorrect
Of the 12 countries in the region, 8 had deficits in 2011.	Of the twelve countries in the region, eight had deficits in 2011.

Exceptions for percentages and currency are described in the following sections.

Dates

Use European style for specific dates.

Prefer	Avoid
1 January, 2012	January 1 2012
	January 1, 2012
	January 1 st , 2012
When specifying years or dates in text, set off the year in commas: From 1	

January, 2011, until 31 December, 2011, the program...

From January 1, 2011 until December 31, 2011 the program...

Time periods

To indicate decades, use the entire year, adding “s” but no apostrophe.

Prefer	Avoid
1960s and 1970s	1960’s, sixties, or ‘60s

Use an en dash when indicating number ranges. Include all four digits of both years in the range.

1999–2004, 2009–2015

4–7 Jan

650–700 tons

When referring to an agricultural season or administrative period (such as a financial year), use a slash rather than an en-dash. The second year can be shortened to two digits.

The 2010/2011 growing season was...

The 2010/11 survey shows...

Do not use dashes with “from/to” or “between/and.”

Prefer	Avoid
From 1995 to 1999	From 1995–1999
Between 1999 and 2004	Between 1999–2004
During the 1997–1999 recession	During 1997–1999

Units of measure

Where possible, use metric (SI) measures and US dollars (written as, for example USD \$200). When local measures or currencies are used, include the metric or US dollar conversion or equivalent. Use standard SI abbreviations with numerals (5 km).

Within a text, spell out “percent” rather than using the symbol “%.” Exceptions can be made for texts that are very number-heavy. Always use numerals with “percent” or “percentage points,” even for

numbers less than 10 (4 percent, 5 percentage points). Use the symbol “%” in tables and figures with numbers, but spell out “percent” as part of an axis label.

Use “percent” with numbers (47 percent of smallholders) and “percentage” as a noun (the percentage of smallholders...) when referring to a portion of something.

References

For publications with a broad audience, use either in-text references with a reference list or endnotes, and follow CMS guidelines.

For scientific publications and journal articles, use the style most appropriate to the field or journal.

Citations

For scientific publications all citations in the text must be expanded in the list of references at the end of the publication.

- All publications included in the list of references should be cited in the text.
- The list of references should be titled “References” and include only citations found in the text. References that are not cited in the text can be listed in a “Bibliography.”
- References should contain the surnames of the authors along with their initials, year of publication, title of paper (in italics), publisher’s name and place of publication.
- List the publications in the list of references alphabetically by author surnames.
- The abbreviation “et al.” should never be used in the list of references. The names of all the authors for a particular publication must be given. With citations in the text, “et al.” can be used where relevant, e.g., Molden et al. 2010.

Format of text citations

The author-year system of citations is used. A citation in a text, table, figure or footnote consists of the author’s surname and the year of publication, usually placed in parentheses with no punctuation in between.

(A) Author names

- a. The surname of the author must be specified, e.g., Merrey
- b. If there are only two authors in the reference, then give the surnames of both authors separated by “and,” e.g., (Hughes and Smakhtin 1996)
- c. If there are more than two authors then give the surname of the first author followed by “et al.,” e.g., Merrey et al. 2006.

(B) Year of publication

- a. The year of publication must be stated after author names with no punctuation in between, e.g., (Merrey 2006)
- b. Use “n.d.” for undated publications, e.g., (Merrey n.d.)

(C) Page(s) – In a citation, a page number or a range of page numbers can be used after the year of publication separated by a colon, e.g., (Merrey 2006: 114) or (Merrey 2006: 114–117)